

Say It Out *Loud*

Ten questions to ask instead of assuming — for the small misunderstandings that quietly pile up.

Here's where this came from. For months I was quietly annoyed that my partner kept moving to my side of the couch. I decided he was crowding me. I said nothing, and let it collect.

When I finally asked, it turned out he was moving *because* he thought I wanted that side. He was being generous. I had spent months resenting an act of kindness.

You can't assume you know what someone wants. Sometimes the thing that looks like inconsideration is someone trying to love you in a way that doesn't quite land.

How to use these

- **Ask one. Not all ten.** This isn't a questionnaire — it's a way out of a story you've been telling yourself.
- **Pick the one that made you flinch.** That's usually the one worth asking.
- **Ask when things are calm,** not mid-argument. The couch conversation went well because nobody was angry yet.
- **Let the answer surprise you.** The whole point is that you might be wrong — and relieved.
- These work for partners, co-parents, roommates, grown siblings, close friends. Anyone you've been quietly deciding about.

Ten questions to ask instead of assuming

Say the quiet thing. Kindly, and out loud.

- 1** "Is there something you've been doing for me that I might not have noticed?"
The couch question. Ask it once and brace yourself — the answer is often lovely.
- 2** "When you do that, what are you hoping I'll feel?"
Separates the intention from the impact. They're rarely the same thing.
- 3** "Is there anything you've been quietly annoyed about?"
Gives them the permission you wish someone had given you.
- 4** "What did you think I meant?"
Ask this before defending yourself. It works almost every time.
- 5** "When I go quiet, what do you assume I'm thinking?"
You'll learn the story they've been running about you. It's usually not the true one.
- 6** "Right now — do you want help, space, or company?"
Three options is easy to answer, even on a bad day. Especially on a bad day.
- 7** "Was that a joke, or did you mean it?"
Two seconds of awkward beats two weeks of wondering.
- 8** "What's one small thing I do that actually makes your day easier?"
Tells you what's landing — so you can stop guessing and do more of it.
- 9** "Is this a 'fix it' or a 'just listen'?"
Most of the friction in a conversation is two people answering different questions.
- 10** "What's one thing you'd change about how we do evenings?"
Small, concrete, low-stakes. A safe place to practise saying it out loud.

If one of these turns into something good, I'd love to hear it — just reply to any Human Note and tell me. I read every one.